

LinguaLounge IPA Reference Sheet: Italian

Base language: English - / / = broad phonemic IPA, [] = common phonetic realization.
Regional pronunciation can vary.

Scope

Standard Italian. Open-mid vs close-mid vowels (/ɛ e/ and /ɔ o/) are real but not always predictable from spelling.

VOWELS

Category	IPA symbols
Stressed vowels	/i e ɛ a ɔ o u/
Unstressed vowels	/i e a o u/
Glides	/j w/

CONSONANTS

Category	IPA symbols
Plosives	/p b t d k g/
Fricatives	/f v s z ʃ/
Affricates	/tʃ dʒ tʃ dʒ/
Nasals	/m n ɲ/
Liquids / glides	/l ʎ r j w/

ALPHABET AND COMMON SPELLING VALUES

The table gives common learner-safe values. Some letters have additional values in loanwords, names, or regional speech.

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
A a	/a/	amore /a'mo:re/	
B b	/b/	bene /'bɛ:ne/	
C c	/t͡ʃ/ or /k/	cena /'t͡ʃe:na/, cane /'ka:ne/	Before e/i -> /t͡ʃ/; otherwise /k/.
Ch ch	/k/	che /ke/, chi /ki/	Hard c before e/i.
D d	/d/	dito /'di:to/	
E e	/e, ɛ/	perché /per'ke/, bene /'bɛ:ne/	The spelling does not always show open/close e.
F f	/f/	faro /'fa:ro/	
G g	/d͡ʒ/ or /g/	gelato /d͡ʒe'la:to/, gatto /'gatto/	Before e/i -> /d͡ʒ/; otherwise /g/.
Gh gh	/g/	ghiro /'gi:ro/	Hard g before e/i.
H h	silent	ho /ɔ/	Also used in ch/gh to keep /k/ and /g/ before e/i.
I i	/i/ or spelling marker	isola /'i:zola/, ciao /'t͡ʃa:ɔ/	In cia/gia, i may only mark softness.
L l	/l/	luna /'lu:na/	
M m	/m/	mare /'ma:re/	
N n	/n/	neve /'ne:ve/	
O o	/o, ɔ/	sole /'so:le/, otto /'ɔtto/	The spelling does not always show open/close o.
P p	/p/	pane /'pa:ne/	
Q q	/kw/	quando /'kwando/	Always followed by u in native spelling.
R r	/r/	Roma /'ro:ma/	Trilled or tapped.
S s	/s/ or /z/	sole /'so:le/, rosa /'rɔ:za/	Intervocalic s is often /z/.
Sc sc	/ʃ/ before e/i	scena /'ʃe:na/	Before a/o/u, sc = /sk/.
T t	/t/	tavola /'ta:vola/	
U u	/u/ or /w/	uno /'u:no/, uomo /'wɔ:mo/	
V v	/v/	voce /'vo:t͡ʃe/	
Z z	/t͡s/ or /d͡z/	pizza /'pitt͡sa/, zero /'d͡ze:ro/	Word-dependent.
Gn gn	/ɲɲ/	bagno /'baɲɲo/	Usually geminate between vowels.
Gli gli	/ʎʎ/	famiglia /fa'miʎʎa/	Usually geminate between vowels.

IMPORTANT SPELLING AND PRONUNCIATION NOTES

Double consonants	Geminate consonants are pronounced long and can change meaning: pala /'pa:la/ vs palla /'palla/.
c/g spelling	c/g are soft before e/i and hard before a/o/u; h makes them hard before e/i: che /ke/, ghi /gi/.
sc, gn, gl	sc before e/i = /ʃ/; gn = /ɲɲ/; gli often = /ʎʎ/.
Stress	Stress often falls on the penultimate syllable, but many words differ. Written accents mark final stress: città /t͡ʃit'ta/.